a.m., when we reached a temporary ‘camp’. Here hundreds and hundreds of mattresses, quilts and pillows were laid out for the yatris to rest, and lunch was served at an adjoining marquee. The walk resumed around 3 p.m., ending at the day’s finish point marked by a giant helium balloon one could spot from a kilometre away.

Reflecting on it, the whole operation was like the military campaign of a mammoth non-violent army. Camps were set up in advance, ready with bedding, food, toilets and electric charging points before the troops arrived. Each day, three sets of camps were set up, one for containers in which Congress leaders, party workers and national yatris stayed and where Rahul Gandhi’s trailer was also parked. The second one, in which I stayed, housed the civil society organizations. We slept not in containers but on bedding on the floor, in all our clothes as it was bitterly cold, and were woken by dew dripping on our faces through the canvas roof of the marquee! We were invariably woken up by cries of ‘*Bistar chhodo, Bharat jodo* (Leave your beds, unite India)!’, my favourite slogan by far, which resounded around the camp, providing much-needed motivation and hilarity. The third camp was for anyone who showed up unexpectedly and for local yatris. The food was rather excellent (perhaps to maintain morale), though the sorry state of the toilets was a dampener. It made for a reliable conversation starter, though, and sociological explanations abounded, including the plausible one that too many were ‘Western-style’, which hundreds of yatris had never encountered before and did not know how to use. It had been my biggest concern about the Yatra, and I was not wrong. But it was salutary that the people invariably ended the Yatra with the sage remark that a yatra was not a yatra, it was a pilgrimage. So if there was any discomfort, one had to just deal with it. Reader, I tried.

Such marches have an honourable and successful precedence. Mahatma Gandhi did the same in 1930 against the British with great effect, when he and Congress workers marched to the coast to make their own salt in defiance of the brutal colonial salt tax. Since then, amassing in huge numbers on public roads to defy an unjust and intransigent regime carries resonance with Indians as a powerful non-violent weapon. Indian farmers